THE MANUFACTURING STRATEGY SERIES · BOOK ONE OF FOUR

DIAGNOSTIC WORKBOOK

Why Great Manufacturers Stay Invisible

Identifying the structural reasons your business is not earning what it is worth

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Worksheets in this workbook

Each worksheet is designed to be used in a leadership session — not read passively. Work through the questions with your management team, using your actual financial and operational data. The answers that are hardest to write down are the ones that matter most.

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Worksheet 1.1

Founder Dependence Check

Answer each question based on what actually happened in the last 30 days — not what the org chart says should happen. Work through this with your management team using actual data.

Who approved customer discounts in the last 30 days?

List every instance — even small, routine ones.

Who resolved the last three major customer complaints?

When a batch was rejected, whose phone rang first?

Who finalised pricing for the last five large orders?

Who decided which RFQs or opportunities to pursue?

Who signed off on routine capital expenses last month?

Cutting tools, machine repairs, consumables — be specific.

THE DIAGNOSIS

If most answers are 'the founder' or 'me', the business has a structural dependency problem. Growth is being throttled by a single point of failure. The market opportunity is larger than the organisation's current decision-making capacity.

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Worksheet 1.2

Growth Plateau Diagnosis

Work from actual financial data — not memory. Pull the last three years of revenue, margin, and customer count before answering.

How many entirely different industries do you currently serve?

Automotive, Aerospace, Agriculture, Textiles, General Engineering — count them all.

What percentage of total revenue comes from your top three customers?

Calculate precisely. Above 60% means growth is controlled by three procurement managers.

Has revenue grown more than 15% in two consecutive years?

State the actual numbers for each of the last three years.

Has EBITDA margin improved over the last 24 months?

Give the actual margin percentage for Year 1, Year 2, and Year 3.

What is the most common reason a new prospect chooses not to buy from you?	*Ask your sales team — record their actual answer, not your assumption.*

THE DIAGNOSIS

If revenue is flat, industry spread is wide, and customer concentration is high, the business is in the Plateau Trap. The symptoms are operational but the root cause is strategic. More machines and more salespeople will not solve a positioning problem.

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Worksheet 1.3

Customer Spread Map

Open your billing software or ERP. Look at actual invoicing data from the last 12 months — not from memory. This exercise often surfaces uncomfortable truths about where management energy is actually going.

Industry served	Main product types / materials	% of total revenue	Margin quality (H/M/L)

THE DIAGNOSIS

If the list looks like a menu from a restaurant that serves every cuisine, the business is spreading itself across markets without depth in any of them. The bottom 20% of revenue almost always consumes the top 40% of operational chaos.

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Worksheet 1.4

Why Do Customers Really Choose Us?

Ask three of your longest-standing customers directly — do not guess. Record the exact words they use. Then apply the Opposite Test to each reason.

Reason 1 — write exactly what the customer said:

Does the opposite of Reason 1 sound absurd? If yes, it is an operating imperative, not an advantage.

Reason 2 — write exactly what the customer said:

Does the opposite of Reason 2 sound absurd?

If a customer had to justify paying you 10% more than a competitor, what exact reason would they give?

This is the hardest question. If the room goes quiet, that silence is the diagnosis.

THE DIAGNOSIS

If three specific, non-generic reasons could not be found, margins will remain under pressure. Buyers cannot see your value because it has not been clearly defined. Recognising this is the first step to building a real strategic advantage.

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Worksheet 1.5

Market Perception Exercise

Do not answer these questions internally. Ask three of your oldest customers and three of your newest customers directly. Record their actual words — not your interpretation.

What specific type of work is our company currently known for?

Record exact customer words.

If a customer refers you to a colleague, what exactly do they say you are good at?

If our competitors described us in one sentence, what would they say?

Competitors are often the most honest source of market perception.

Which single capability, if lost, would cause the most customers to leave immediately?

This is the one worth building a strategy around.

THE DIAGNOSIS

If the answers reveal that customers value you primarily for low price or availability, the business has not yet created a differentiated position. If answers reveal genuine, specific technical capability — that is the foundation to build on.

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Worksheet 1.6

Where Might We Win?

Generate three to five specific market arenas where your current capabilities could create a structural advantage. Complete all three columns honestly for each.

Potential arena	Why we might win here	What would have to be true?

THE DIAGNOSIS

Focus only on markets where you can actively build the conditions for victory — not markets that depend on external events outside your control. The third column is the most important.

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The diagnostic questions in this workbook are designed to be worked through in a leadership session. The answers that are hardest to write down — the ones that require looking at actual data rather than intuition — are the ones that matter most.

If working through these worksheets has surfaced a strategic question your leadership team cannot yet answer clearly — about where to compete, how to invest, or what to test before committing capital — that question is where the advisory work begins.

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